

Name: _____

Date: _____

The Night Walk at Camp Wattlebird

Year 6 reading comprehension · Story · 13 marks · About 30 minutes

Camp Wattlebird sat at the edge of a dark and rustling forest, and tonight, Ava had decided she would rather be anywhere else. The whole of Year 6 stood in a huddle outside the dining hall, clutching torches, while Ranger Min explained the plan. A night walk. In the bush. With the lights off.

“Your eyes are cleverer than you think,” said Ranger Min. “Give them ten minutes in the dark, and you’ll see things you never noticed.” Beside Ava, Jasper snorted. “Ten minutes of nothing, you mean.” But Ava noticed that he had edged closer to the group.

The track wound uphill between towering gums. Torch beams swung left and right, catching the glint of spider webs and the startled eyes of a possum. Somewhere above, an owl called, a low, hollow note that made Ava’s skin prickle. She kept her torch aimed at her boots and counted her steps.

At the top of the hill, Ranger Min stopped. “Torches off,” she said.

The darkness fell like a heavy blanket. Ava’s heart thudded against her ribs. She could not see her own hands. A twig snapped; someone gasped; someone else laughed nervously. She wanted to switch her torch back on so badly that her thumb twitched against the button.

“Breathe,” murmured Ranger Min. “And wait.”

Ava breathed. She waited. Slowly, strangely, the black began to soften. The outlines of the trees appeared, then the glow of the sky between their branches, and then, all at once, the stars: thousands upon thousands, scattered across the darkness like spilled salt. Ava forgot to be afraid.

“Whoa,” whispered Jasper. For once, he had nothing clever to say. Ava smiled in the dark. She had come to the bush expecting to be scared, and instead she had found something she would remember for the rest of her life.

1. What was the name of the camp? (1 mark)

2. The story says the students stood “in a huddle.” What does “huddle” mean? (1 mark)

3. How did Ava feel about the night walk at the start of the story? Cite two details that show this. (2 marks)

4. The story says, “The darkness fell like a heavy blanket.” What does this comparison suggest about the dark? (2 marks)

5. What can you infer about Jasper from the way he behaves? Use evidence from the story. (2 marks)

6. Quote the sentence that shows Ava’s feelings had changed. Then explain how it shows the change. (2 marks)

7. Why was Ranger Min’s advice to “breathe” and “wait” important? Support your answer with evidence from the text. (2 marks)

8. Choose the statement that best expresses a theme of the story. Write its letter. (1 mark)

- A. Facing something you fear can lead to a wonderful surprise.
- B. Forests are always dangerous at night, so people should avoid them.
- C. Torches are more important than stars on a bush walk.
- D. The loudest students are always the bravest in the dark.

Answer: _____

Writing task: Write about a time you did something you were nervous about. What did you discover?
